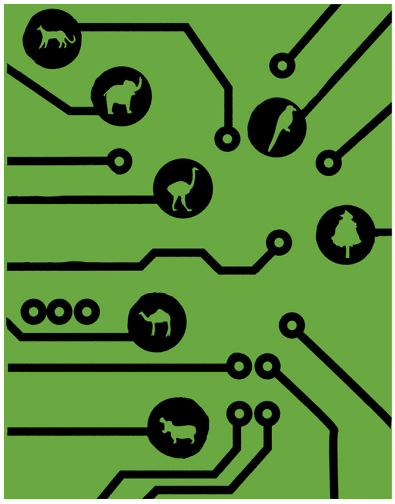


SPECIES MAINTAIN THE FUNCTIONING AND STABILITY OF ECOSYSTEMS

BIODIVERSITY AND ECOSYSTEM FUNCTION

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Michel Loreau (1954–)

BEFORE

1949 At the California Institute of Technology in the US, the first phytotron (research greenhouse) is built to study how an artificial ecosystem can be manipulated.

1991 In the UK, an Ecotron, a set of experimental ecosystems in computer-controlled units, is created at Imperial College, London.

AFTER

2014 Leading ecologists in the US say that the effect of diversity loss on ecosystems is at least as great as—or even greater than—that of fire, drought, or other drivers of environmental change.

2015 A paper published in *Nature* provides evidence that biodiversity increases an ecosystem's resilience in a broad range of climate events.

In an age when human activities are rapidly eroding the complex mix of species in different habitats, ecologists have increasingly focused on how biodiversity loss affects the way ecosystems work. If species are replaced or